

every gust of wind from the river carrying whispers of times that had seen a Tulsidas being born, or the Ramanandi *sampradaya* setting up camp two centuries later—it was hobbled by its limited, pre-modern infrastructure.

Now, that historic Ayodhya townscape has given way to a growing crescendo of contemporary urbanity: broad avenues and highways, opulent hotels, futuristic 3D paintings, luxury tent cities, a greenfield township. Tradition will be gestured at with murals and architectural facades. In the past three years, Ayodhya has been in makeover mode. It is now a city of 36 new hotels, 600 homestays and almost one dozen tent cities, with half-a-dozen new roads and UP's first app-based EV cab facility—and yes, a spanking new airport and railway station. With a Nagara-style façade complete with shikharas and dotted with murals and artworks, the Maharishi Valmiki International Airport Ayodhya Dham terminal will eventually be scaled up to cater to six million visitors annually. The old railway station, a secondary one to the main Ayodhya Cantonment station, could take merely 25 trains and 10,000 passengers. The three-storey Ayodhya Dham—outfitted with lifts, escalators, food plazas and what have you—can handle 40 trains and some 70,000 passengers a day.

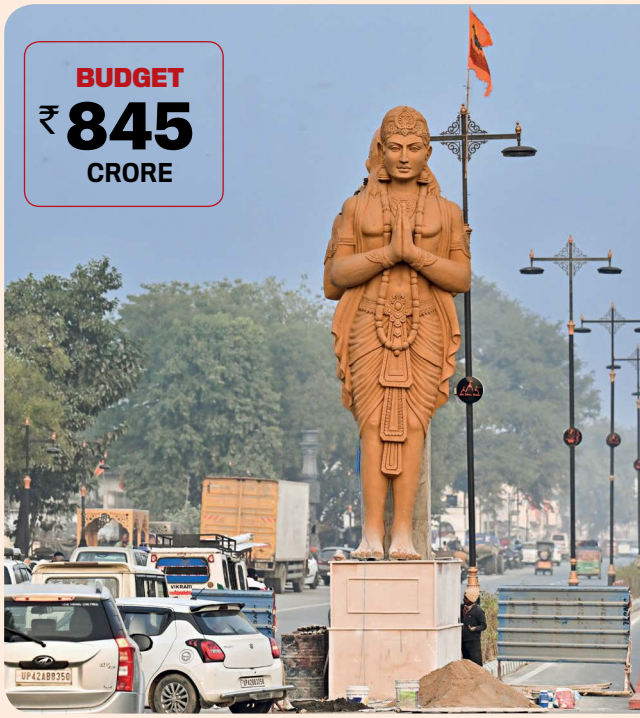
HISTORIC AYODHYA WILL GIVE WAY TO CONTEMPORARY URBANITY: WIDE AVENUES, OPULENT HOTELS, A GREENFIELD TOWNSHIP

In a town whose denizens numbered a bonsai-scale 55,890 in 2011 and are still shy of 80,000, that's quite a Malthusian curve to handle. Ayodhya has been in beaver-mode, building room to absorb all that exploding population. Three temporary tent cities, with space for 80,000 devotees, catered to the rush that came in for the January 22 *pran pratishtha* ceremony. Commercial ones too are ready. Says Krishan Kant, the manager at 'Praveg', one of the tent cities near the temple that hit the news because of its Gujarati ownership: "We have created 30 tent cottages with waterproof tents, an AC restaurant, and open-air seating for a premium experience." Besides, over 600 applications for homestays and 37 non-branded three-star hotels have been cleared in the past year, says Vishal Singh, vice-chairman, Ayodhya Development Authority (ADA). Officials have been working marathon hours to verify the applications, get police verifications done and check safety measures before uploading the licences on an app. Nor are the rich being discriminated against. "We already have Radisson up and running. Taj Group is coming with its two brands. So is Lemon Tree. We have also got a proposal for a seven-star resort," says Singh. For those who may like to settle down amidst all the sacredness, a 1,407-acre greenfield township is coming up astride the Lucknow-Gorakhpur national highway. There are many who have been unsettled too, old natives, but then this was not the consecration of Daridra Narayan.

The ADA has been buzzing like a beehive, daily

FOUR PATHS TO RAM

One of the most attractive and central features of the Ayodhya redevelopment, these four new roads inaugurated on Dec. 30 last year replace narrow, congested lanes



Photographs by MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

RAM PATH ▲

The 13-km-long, four-lane road connects Sahadatganj in the district to Nayaghat in Ayodhya, also links to Lucknow-Ayodhya-Gorakhpur national highway. Shops and shutters on either side are bedecked with religious symbols; houses are painted in shades of peach with white temple-shaped motifs. Buses and cabs are allowed.